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How a Creative Speech Creates

In 1998, Madeleine L'Engle received the Margaret A. Edwards Award from the American Library Association. The award is given to authors who have made significant and lasting contributions to young adult literature; L'Engle is the author behind the popular novel “A Wrinkle in Time,” as well as other lauded works aimed towards the YA audience. In her acceptance speech on June 27th of that year, after voicing her appreciation, L'Engle takes the time to address how YA literature—and fiction writing as a whole—has affected and evolved with society, and asserts the importance of both of these crafts. To her, the continued creation of innovative stories is itself a means of propelling society, and humanity, forwards. L'Engle references historical trends while making frequent use of personal anecdotes, fluidly interweaving these elements to engage and persuade her audience, in a way ensuring that listeners know that she knows, and cares about, what she is advocating for.

L'Engle's opening anecdote is one centered on her writing, her characters, and, crucially, the demonstrable effect they have had on readers and the world. She speaks of having a discussion with a group of students familiar with her work:

We talked about future plans for some of the characters, and I was able to tell them that Polly O'Keefe is in medical school.

A few days later I received a letter from one of the students saying that she was a first year medical student at Yale, and that she and her friends would love to have Polly O'Keefe in their class.

I wrote back that Polly would be delighted to be part of their class.

The next letter I received told me that they had gone to the office and registered Polly, so now she is an official member of the student body at Yale Medical School. (L'Engle)

This narrative spearheads the speech, plants itself in the audience's heads before the topic of YA literature itself is so much as approached—L'Engle sets up the case she endeavors to make later on with this somewhat whimsical, yet still potent example of fiction having enough of a hold on people to impact reality proper. This story also further raises L'Engle's credibility as an appeal to ethos; though already giving a speech in response to being awarded, she starts off with an instance of her writing tangibly affecting others/the world in a substantial way, hammering home that she is an accomplished figure without being too overbearing—said whimsicality of a fictional character being officially enrolled in a school does well to illustrate (or at least foreshadow) L'Engle's point about the importance of writing while keeping the mood light. Her use of language also serves to heighten this effect: L'Engle takes care to refer to Polly by name—aside from L'Engle herself, Polly is the only named figure in this story—so it's easy to see the importance attributed to her, even though the audience is aware Polly is fictional. Capping off this section, she turns to credit said audience, both active listeners as well as her readerbase, saying that, in regards to her characters, “Sometimes they know more than [she does], and sometimes they know before [she does].” Alongside the fun anecdote, this simple recognition of the audience's role in the process of giving value to fiction helps L'Engle make an appeal to pathos as well, a pleasant “isn't it neat that this happened?” that encourages listeners to laugh with her, welcoming them in before she moves on to address heavier matters.

Staying on the topic of her writing and characters, L'Engle's followup to Polly's enrollment is a more solemn recount of drafting one of her novels, *The Arm of the Starfish*; she

gives a brief overview of the plot, again describing her characters as if they were real people, and lands on how a “Joshua” appeared in the story, to both her and the protagonist’s surprise. Before settling into a similar tone as the previous anecdote, though, L’Engle tells of her ten-year-old son’s reaction upon hearing her read her final draft aloud—“When I got to the scene where Joshua is shot and killed, my son said, ‘Change it.’/‘I can’t change it,’ I said. ‘That’s what happened.’” She tells of how she maintained her position, repeating herself even when her son pushed back, arguing that, as the writer, the story was literally hers to change. This anecdote marks the speech’s shift into not exactly somber, but more serious, earnest matters. As an emotionally charged story, it appeals to both pathos and ethos—pathos through its framing as a moment of pseudo-mourning between mother and child over one of her creations (one that would hit all the harder for listeners familiar with and invested in the novel), and ethos through the same, showing a sort of vulnerability and personability, a willingness to be open with the audience. Overall, the effect achieved by this anecdote is much the same as the one prior, despite the tonal shift; L’Engle then capitalizes on this shift to move through a sequence of historical points, continuing on this winding path to build towards her ultimate message about writing.

In fairly rapid succession, and following an almost stream-of-consciousness style of direction, the speech touches on the concept of truth, the evolution of language, and the related evolution of certain aspects of social culture. Right out of the previous anecdote, L’Engle speaks on the difference between truth and fact; she says she wasn’t able to change what had happened because that would have deviated from the truth of the story. She quotes Pilates’ “What is truth?” and gives a response: “Truth does not contradict or deny facts, but it goes through and beyond facts.” She then references the book *The Wind in the Willows* as a piece of religious writing that, in its going beyond of fact, has become “deeply upsetting and untruthful to some people,” and

points towards imagination as being at the root of that upsetting. Her next move is to detail how the definition and use of the word “imagination” have changed over time, how, in the King James Bible, it is always bad—the entirety of this truth-focused section, albeit brief, acts as a pivot point, a springboard into the next big topic. However, the content here is by no means aimless; L’Engle has used this stop to neatly pack away rich ideas in support of her later claims—namely that of how the weight of both truth and imagination stems from their capacity to go beyond fact (and so the “real”), a tenet that solidly backs the importance of fiction writing, even though she has not made any claims about that yet.

It is with her thoughts on “imagination” that L’Engle begins to piece together her argument for the audience. She remarks on how there are still people in modern times who keep imagination at an arm’s length, and says that they are “thinking about it as it was defined three centuries ago.” She lists a few more words too: “prevent” deriving from roots meaning “to go before,” and “let” originally meaning “to stop,” both words now turned on their heads. With these examples as a foundation, she starts speaking about the role of authors in such changes, and broader ones as well—she cites James Joyce as someone who had a drastic effect on how people sought to express their interiority through language, and Chaucer as the reason we speak English at all. These hard-set references to historical linguistic developments create a basis for appeals to logos in L’Engle’s argument; having touched on how writing can affect people through personal stories, she leverages history to establish the opposite, how writing and language are changed over time by people, too. Carrying on, she covers how modern media has affected language, a prominent change being how people are now so often referred to as consumers; she takes issue here, and pushes for people being “nourishers” in this context, something less destructive. And, at this point, after a fair bit of somewhat circuitous set-up, L’Engle is ready to pull all these

threads together—she finally makes her first clear, overt claim about writing: “We live in a world which has changed radically in the last half century, and story helps us to understand and live creatively with change.”

All the anecdotes and references before this statement have been thematically related (some more tenuously than others), but lacked an overarching connective tissue—L’Engle did not place a thesis statement at the start of her speech. Instead, she opted to piece out examples of the importance of stories bit by bit, jumping between a wide array of subjects—after she does lay that claim bare, it becomes obvious that everything she has said has been to bolster it, proof from all facets of life that stories and writing have tangible weight. The speech goes from placing a sort of nebulous value on creative work to being a lot more focused in this one line—it’s as if L’Engle approached structuring the speech as a compelling story, wherein there are seeds planted early on the audience won’t fully understand until later. This revelation-esque moment is followed by L’Engle doubling down on changes in the world, almost picking up pace—she runs through how some theories first explored in science fiction have, with technological advancements, really come to pass, how social standards surrounding vulgarity and taboos have shifted, and stresses the fact that, so long as people are, these changes will not stop. She notes the importance of the writer again, as an individual who can break social convention through their art—again, the evolution of story goes hand-in-hand with the evolution of humanity. On YA literature specifically, she praises its capacity to give validity to its young protagonists—she describes it as an “honoring of the human spirit” that allows readers to “enter into the subject, to feel empathy, to be willing to be part of the story.” Here is where her exigence becomes apparent, too—L’Engle, as a writer, has seen firsthand both the positive, enriching changes stories can affect on people, but also the prevalence of those who discredit the art. Through the patchwork

nature of her speech, she imparts this ubiquitous quality of writing to her audience, an assurance that the effect of engaging with stories can be seen in all parts of life.

Nearing the end of her speech, L'Engle makes another assertion about writing, a response she once gave: "Someone said, 'It's all been done before.'/Yes, I agreed, but we all have to say it in our own voice." The context of this line is as a conclusion to some musings on genre, and how there are stories that have persisted throughout human history in the form of fairy tales and myths. Much like many other statements in the speech, though, it can be applied to far more. A notable instance of this ideal's potency would be L'Engle's speech itself. Her main idea—that writing and stories are important—is certainly not original, but each rhetorical move she makes, from opening with a plethora of initially uncentered topics, to recounting so many of her own experiences, alters the impact she has—she literally takes that idea, and, through her voice, creates something new. With careful language—each new idea sprung on the audience in the first half of the speech is introduced with short, easy to digest sentences—and a warm, personable tone, L'Engle crafts herself (and her argument) more grounds to stand on; she's able to not just present her argument, but truly communicate it.

Works Cited

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